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CAPITOL TALES The US Capitol, possibly the most culturally and historically important building in the US, has been home to the Congress since 1800

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SPACEWALK At the National Air and Space Museum, explore artefacts that are literally out of this world

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PARTY TIME The Library of Congress's Thomas Jefferson Building throws opens its doors to the general public every Thursday evening for the best party in town



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drinks and food available for purchase in the Great Hall while appreciating the stunning architecture of the Jefferson Building and engaging with the Library's exhibits, collections, and programmes. Well, having a party in a library is one bucket list item ticked off!

The US has long been a popular holiday destina-

tion for Indians. Almost everyone knows someone who either lives or studies in the US, and visiting them combined with a holiday works for us. Little wonder, Indians are the second-largest source market for Washington, DC, tourism. In 2023, more than 165,000 Indians visited Washington, DC, and spent a total of \$287,400,000, making them popular with local businesses and hospitality outlets.

While we happily spend on shopping, stay and eating out, we Indians certainly appreciate a good bargain. And Washington appeals to us because many activities in the city are free! Consider this: there are 17 Smithsonian museums and galleries in the city, and all offer free entry. However, it is necessary to book a slot online to avoid overcrowding. My favourites are the National Museum of Natural History and the National Air and Space Museum. The Museum of Natural History, which is larger than 18 football fields, has the world's largest natural history collection. Delve into the fascinating story of our planet, from its fiery beginnings through billions of years of transformation, and explore life on Earth through exhibitions and activities. Or, like me, head straight to the gems and jewellery gallery with the famed Hope Diamond. Before coming to the Smithsonian, the Hope Diamond travelled from a mine in India to the court of Louis XIV in France and from the merchant houses of Europe to the homes of the American elite. Harry Winston, an American jeweller, donated it to the museum in 1958. Since then, over 100 million visitors have viewed this unique 45-carat blue diamond.

At the Air and Space Museum, you can take your curiosity to new heights as you explore artefacts that are truly out of this world! For me, the highlight was Neil Armstrong's Apollo 11 spacesuit and the Wright brothers' first aircraft from 1903.

Washington is multi-cultural and brimming with art, music, dance, museums, and theatres of every type along with restaurants serving cuisines from across the globe. The Wharf on DC's waterfront is one of the most popular restaurant destinations where residents and visitors alike can take advantage of fine dining, casual cafes, and gourmet on-the-go.

On my way back to the hotel after a particularly satisfying dinner, I asked my Uber driver who he thought would be the next resident of the White House. Harris, he hoped, but America is a large country, so you never know, he said, shaking his head. Will she? Will she not? **BT**

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